discrimination, child labour, poor governance and corruption, as well as a host of other issues. Just as placards, slogans and hundreds of protestors from around the world have become a standard feature of these meetings, so has tight security, with the five or so city blocks that house the offices of the World Bank and the IMF cordoned off and several layers of security to ensure access only to authorized personnel. As a central bank governor, I enjoyed privileged security clearance; even so, going in and out was always quite a hassle and I tried to stay within the security cordon all through the business day.

It is standard practice during these international meetings for the Indian delegation to park themselves in the spacious office complex of India's executive director at the IMF which is located in the HQ1 building of the IMF. The G20 meeting venue was in the adjacent HQ2. In other times, my inclination would have been to walk across to the meeting but since that would involve moving in and out of security, my staff navigated me through the basement tunnel connecting the two buildings.

By the time I entered the meeting hall shortly before starting time, I was still unsure about whether I could weave a coherent narrative from my jumbled thoughts. The meeting was organized around a large quadrangular table with the finance ministers and governors of the G20 'troika' (Brazil, the current chair; South Africa, the chair of the previous year, 2007; and UK, the chair for the following year, 2009) seated on one side while the rest of us occupied the other three sides. The ministers and governors sat in the front row with two deputies per delegation in the back row. The managing director of the IMF, Dominique Strauss-Kahn, and the president of the World Bank, Robert Zoellick, and their support staff too were present. It was a fairly large meeting with about 125 of us in there. The atmosphere was decidedly sombre with the usual pre-meeting banter unusually low-key.

After a brief introduction by the chair, the meeting rolled on with Hank Paulson, the US treasury secretary, giving an account of the hectic activity during the week and the weekend prior to 16 September when Lehman Brothers filed for bankruptcy, setting off tumultuous developments in the global financial markets. Although Ben Bernanke, the chairman of the